

Building an Inclusive Culture

Make inclusion real, not a slogan

4 psychology approaches · tips & advice — by EvaTalk

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BEFORE YOU BEGIN

Make inclusion real, not a slogan

Many organizations display inclusion values... that stay slogans. A real inclusive culture isn't decreed in a charter: it's built in practices, from hiring to promotion, from daily life to decisions.

This guide helps you examine the current culture, move past 'cosmetic' inclusion, and put structural, measurable levers in place.

Your intention

An aspect of your organization's culture you want to make more inclusive: _____

The 4 approaches

This guide works your topic through 4 complementary psychology lenses. Read, do the exercises, fill the workbook — at your own pace.

Psychodynamic — understand the root.

CBT — ease the negative thoughts.

Humanistic — reconcile with yourself.

Systemic — act on your environment.

The invisible culture

Every organization has implicit norms: who feels 'they belong', who has to adapt, what's valued without being said. Often, a gap separates the stated values from the lived culture.

Making this implicit culture visible is the first lever.

Example

Sure it was 'inclusive', a team realized its rituals (after-work drinks) quietly excluded several profiles.

My implicit culture

In my team/organization: who feels they belong? who has to adapt? what's valued without being said?

The values / reality gap

Where do our stated values and lived reality diverge?

→ *An inclusive culture starts with seeing its implicit culture.*

Moving past cosmetic inclusion

'We have a charter, so we're good', 'we already hire diverse': these thoughts give the illusion of having acted. Diversity (being present) isn't inclusion (feeling you belong).

Returning to facts and data avoids self-congratulation.

Example

Proud of its charter, a company looked at its numbers: promotions never went to diverse profiles. The charter wasn't enough.

Beyond the slogan

Note a 'proof of inclusion' we settle for — and the real data that tests it.

Diversity ≠ inclusion

Distinguish: who's present (diversity) / who feels they belong and progresses (inclusion).

→ *Being diverse isn't being inclusive: the proof is in the facts.*

The sense of belonging

At the heart of inclusion: that everyone feels they belong, safe to be themselves and contribute. That's belonging — deeper than mere presence.

We stay, invest, and create where we feel we belong.

Example

By creating spaces where everyone could be themselves, a leader saw engagement — and retention — rise.

The sense of belonging

Who in the organization may NOT feel they belong? What signals that to them?

My role as an example

How, through my attitude, can I widen the sense of belonging?

→ *Inclusion is everyone genuinely feeling they belong.*

Structural levers

An inclusive culture is built through levers: equitable hiring/evaluation/promotion, psychological safety, a reporting channel, sponsoring underrepresented talent, data & goals, and leadership setting the example.

What's measured and embodied at the top truly changes the culture.

Example

By setting clear criteria and tracking promotion data, an organization corrected a long-standing imbalance in two years.

My levers

Pick 2-3 structural levers to activate (criteria, data, sponsoring, reporting).

What I measure

Which data will I track (hiring, promotion, departures, sentiment)?

→ *An inclusive culture is built through measurable levers.*

Practical tips & advice

Tips & advice

- Measure: who's hired, promoted, who leaves, who speaks — data reveals reality.
- Make processes equitable (clear criteria, panels) from hiring to promotion.
- Create psychological safety and a safe reporting channel.
- Actively sponsor underrepresented talent.
- Train managers — inclusion plays out day to day.
- Involve leadership: example at the top changes everything. Go beyond charters.

To fill in

Our culture

Aspect	Stated	Lived (data/fact)

My levers

Lever to activate	What I measure

PLAN

Your 4-week plan

Week 1 — See our invisible culture.

Week 2 — Move past cosmetic inclusion.

Week 3 — Cultivate the sense of belonging.

Week 4 — Activate structural levers.

Your plan in 3 lines

- The values/reality gap I target:
- The structural lever I activate:
- The data I measure:

TO CLOSE

Not a slogan: an inclusive culture is built — and measured.

Not a slogan: measurable practices.

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